assertions that it is not a personal issue, it is evident that it always has been for him a personal issue which reflects his deep animosity towards Mr Ratan N. Tata.'

Cyrus attacked Ratan at all levels. He termed his predecessor's 'decision-making' as 'capricious'. To illustrate his claims, he said that Corus was acquired to satisfy Ratan's 'ego'. He could not furnish any evidence to support the allegation, though. On the contrary as most of the Tata veterans opined, the acquisition was important for the growth of Tata Steel as it could not grow organically, because of myriad problems in the country.

The public mudslinging and constant attacks took its toll on Ratan, affecting both his emotional and physical health. Publicly acknowledging the pain the allegations were causing him, at the Tata Chemicals EGM held on 24 December 2016, he said: 'Over the last two months there has been a definite move to damage my personal reputation and the reputation of this great group—the Tata Group. These days are very lonely, newspapers are full of attacks, most of them unsubstantiated but nevertheless painful.'

Speaking in 2019, three years after Mistry was replaced as chairman, Ratan said that he had been left with virtually no choice: 'I dealt with the leadership, or lack of leadership that took place in 2016. It wasn't to go back in. That was not the reason. The reason for me to go back was because I needed only to satisfy my inner self, to know that I didn't stand by and just watch something severe that was happening. Because human nature is such that someone will look you in the eye and ask, but where were you? Why didn't you do something about it? So, that was the one thing I actually agonized over: should I intervene or should I not?'

The cases in the NCLT saw some of the most well-known Indian legal luminaries arrayed against each other. About 140 cases were filed across courts in Mumbai and New Delhi. After hearing the matter for nearly two years, a two-member bench of B.S.V. Prakash Kumar and V. Nallasenapathy gave its verdict on 12 July 2018, holding that it did not find merit in any of Mistry's major contentions.

Most significantly, it said that Mistry's 'removal' was because the board of directors and the majority shareholder, Tata Trusts, had lost confidence in his leadership, not because of the concern that 'Mr Cyrus would cause discomfort to Mr Tata, Mr Soonawala' and others 'over purported legacy issues'. Another reason given by the bench for Mistry's removal from the directorship was that 'he admittedly sent the company information to